

Lower-order a worthy fail-safe but overdependence can be costly

India's transitioning top-order can't rely solely on the stability of Ravindra Jadeja, Ravichandran Ashwin and Axar Patel. Rohit Sharma's team **must enforce** more accountability at the top to succeed in this Test season.

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India was tottering at 144 for six; a young and sprightly Bangladeshi pace attack had sent a vaunted top-order packing under overcast conditions in Chennai. That's when the ageing Ravindra Jadeja and Ravichandran Ashwin were called upon to mitigate the damage.

The duo responded with a 199-run partnership for the seventh wicket, pulling India to 376 in the first innings, which Bangladesh could just about overhaul in its two innings combined. That they picked 11 wickets between them with their primary skill to script India's 280-run win was secondary, and rightly so.

India has lost just four Tests at home since December 2012, and the spin duo has been the centrepiece of this invincibility. They have been part of 44 Tests at home since 2013, of which India has won 34 and lost just three, translating to a win percentage of 77.27.

Despite 800 Test wickets between them, the



Ashwin-Jadeja combine also tells a tale of a lower-order resistance with the bat that has allowed India to preserve its indomitable record at home in the longest format. **It also includes the grit and valiance of other members of the spin tribe — Axar Patel and Kuldeep Yadav — who have extended India's tail.**

Be it Ashwin and Dhruv Jurel combining in Rajkot for the eighth wicket against England earlier this